

Trumped by Trump? Public Support for Vote By Mail Voting in Response to the COVID-19 Pandemic

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Abstract:

How much is support for vote by mail (VBM) impacted by the COVID-19 pandemic, partisanship, and recent efforts by partisan elites to politicize discussions about expanding the use of VBM in November 2020? Using surveys of registered voters conducted in April and May 2020 we characterize how changing concerns about COVID 19 and increased partisan messaging affects public support for VBM. We show that the bipartisan support for VBM in April 2020 falls sharply after just six weeks because: Republicans became less worried about catching COVID-19, and unconcerned Republicans also became more opposed to VBM. The pandemic originally increased public support for expanding VBM to help combat the spread of COVID-19—creating a relative unique opportunity to examine the public’s willingness to reconsider how elections are administered—but decreasing COVID-19 concerns among Republicans and increased opposition among unconcerned Republicans (perhaps due to increased partisan messaging) has combined to increase partisan divisions in otherwise historically high levels of public support for VBM.

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The COVID-19 pandemic has brought into sharp focus the differences in how citizens vote across the United States. Over the past few months, there has been extensive discussion about how elections should be conducted in the midst of a pandemic. These public discussions have been motivated by long-standing partisan considerations as well as newly emergent public health concerns because of COVID-19. The 2020 Wisconsin primary on April 7, 2020 highlighted for many how the decisions made by elected officials and the courts could dramatically affect how people are able to vote during a worldwide pandemic (Wise and Corse 2020). The COVID-19 pandemic has consequently prompted new debates about the efficacy and desirability of voting by mail (VBM) and these debates raise important questions about the nature of public support for expanding VBM— support that is presumably essential for understanding the incentives that re-election motivated elected officials might have when considering whether to change how elections are conducted.

Critical to understanding public support for expanding VBM during the COVID-19 pandemic is the ability to disentangle the relative importance of public health and partisan considerations. We question how changing concerns about catching COVID-19 impact public support for expanding VBM and whether increased partisan messaging around the expansion of VBM has caused public opinion to be more impacted by public health or partisan considerations over time.

Most prior research focuses on the impact of early voting on turnout and political participation rather than on the reasons for public support. Scholars have examined important questions such as which demographic groups are more likely to vote early (e.g., Ashok, Feder, McGrath and Hersh 2016; Gronke and Miller 2012; Kropf 2012; Monroe and Sylvester 2011; Stein 1998), whether early voting reforms increase turnout (e.g., Berinsky, Burns and Traugott

2001; Burden, Canon, Mayer and Moynihan 2009; Herron, Smith and Walker 2019; Gronke, Galanes-Rosenbaum and Miller 2007), and whether early voting has a partisan advantage for Democratic or Republican candidates (e.g., Burden, Canon, Mayer and Moynihan 2017; Garcia-Monet and Stein 1997). Other research has focused on voter confidence and perceptions of voter fraud relating to early voting (e.g., Ansolabehere, Persily and Stewart 2016; Sances and Stewart 2015), effects of early voting on electoral outcomes (Meredith and Malhotra 2011), the policy costs of early voting reforms (Stewart 2011), and the possible effects early voting has on civic engagement (Ritchey 2005; Thompson 2004).

Although much has been learned, it is less clear how various considerations can impact the support for various election reforms, and the extent to which partisan cues can be overcome by other considerations. Excellent work has certainly studied the public opinion of early voting reforms, including vote-by-mail (e.g., Alvarez, Hall, Levin and Stewart 2011; Burchett and Southwell 1997; Burden, Canon, Mayer and Moynihan 2011; Southwell 2004), but it is unclear how the COVID-19 pandemic has changed how the public evaluates VBM and whether new considerations such as concerns with catching COVID-19 can overcome partisan cues. Better understanding the relative importance of such considerations for public opinion over time is essential for knowing whether bottom-up public pressures for VBM are likely to emerge despite the opposition of Republican elites.

On the one hand, COVID-19 concerns may cause those who would otherwise oppose VBM to reconsider their opposition. Fears about the new virus may cause individuals to become more supportive of being able to vote from the privacy of their own home. On the other hand, increased messaging by Republican elites – and President Trump in particular – against suggestions to expand VBM to help limit the spread of the pandemic may result in increasing

partisan differences in public opinion. Although we know public opinion is generally responsive to partisan cues in general (e.g., Zaller 1992) and to President Trump in particular (Barber and Pope 2018), it is unclear how important partisan cues are during a pandemic when individuals are concerned with their personal safety.

To assess the changing relative importance of partisanship and COVID-19 concerns for expanding VBM in the 2020 presidential election, we conduct two nationally-representative surveys of registered voters in April and May 2020. The timing of our surveys is fortuitous because partisan messaging by President Trump about the undesirability of VBM increased considerably during the field period of our second survey—thereby increasing the strength of partisan cues for respondents to our second survey. Because we are able to compare the levels and change in public opinion we collect to responses collected in the 2016 *Survey of the Performance of American Elections*⁵ we are also able to examine how public support compared to pre-pandemic circumstances.

Although we show that concern with catching COVID-19 is strongly related to increased support for VBM, we show that the bipartisan support for expanding VBM in April 2020 disappears by the end of May because of diminished Republican support for two reasons. First, Republican support for VBM decreases over the six week period we examine because Republicans becoming less concerned with catching COVID-19. A second reason for the increasing partisan gap over time is because opposition to VBM increases over time among Republicans who are unconcerned with catching COVID-19. Thus, while the pandemic has indeed increased support for VBM, the shifts we detect (only) among Republicans suggests that

⁵The survey was conducted in November of 2016, following the general election. Data available at: <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/Y38VIQ>

the increased messaging by Republican elites on the pandemic and on VBM is largely responsible for the changes in Republican opinion we identify.

In contrast to support for expanding VBM to help combat the pandemic, public support for other potential election reforms, including increasing the number of polling places, extending voter registration periods, and expanding early voting is relatively stable. The fact that public support for these reforms is unrelated to COVID-19 concerns suggests the popularity of these reforms regardless of COVID-19.

We establish our argument as follows. Section 1 discusses support for expanding VBM over time. Section 2 analyzes the correlates of public opinion to quantify how partisanship and COVID-19 concerns predict support for expanding VBM. Section 3 replicates the analysis using other electoral reforms to show that public support for other electoral reforms is relatively stable either because voters believe that they are reforms that should occur regardless of the pandemic or else the reforms have not been as politicized as VBM, and section 4 concludes with the implications of our findings for understanding public support for expanding VBM.

1. Public Support for VBM Over Time

Because elected officials in state governments must decide how to conduct elections in their state, understanding the nature of public support for various alternatives is critical for assessing the extent to which “bottom-up” pressure may create an impetus for changing how elections are conducted. The overall level of public support is important because re-election focused elites tend to take positions reflect the opinion of the majority (e.g., Ahler and Broockman 2018), but it is also important to understand how support varies by partisanship given the polarization of state legislatures (e.g., Shor and McCarty 2010).

Better understanding the extent to which partisan considerations determine public opinion towards election reforms and whether other considerations can overcome partisan cues is critical for understanding whether public pressures for electoral reforms are possible in the absence of elite leadership. If only partisan considerations matter for the public's support of election reforms, reforms are unlikely in the absence of elite support and agreement.

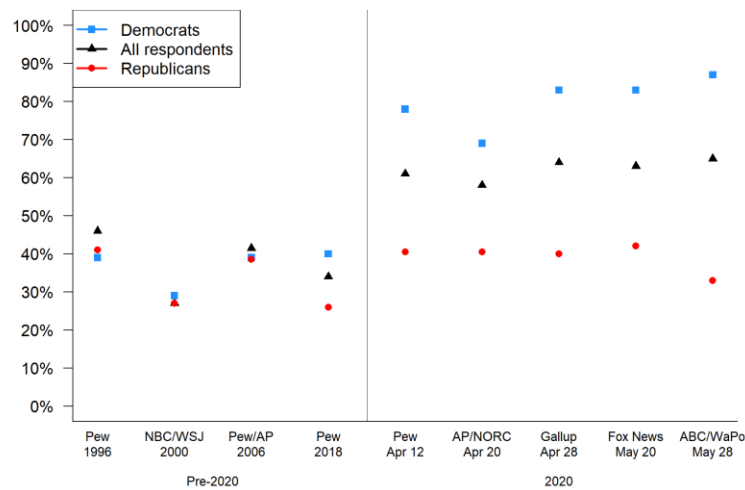
The COVID-19 pandemic presents a unique opportunity to investigate public opinion about election administration. Not only has the pandemic created new considerations for citizens to ponder when deciding whether to support or oppose expanding VBM, but events like the Wisconsin primary have also provide ample opportunity for partisan elites to express their support or opposition to VBM. Have shared concerns with catching COVID-19 lessened the partisan opinion gap or has partisan messaging increased partisan differences?⁶

To begin, it is useful to compare public support for VBM over time. Using the Roper Center survey archives, four surveys conducted prior to the COVID-19 pandemic ask questions that are comparable to post-pandemic surveys. Although the questions being asked slightly vary (see Appendix A), each clearly measures public support for allowing more (or all) voters to vote by mail.⁷ Figure 1 presents the aggregate time series to reveal two clear patterns.

⁶ Of course, there are also partisan-related differences in the extent to which individuals are concerned with catching COVID-19 that must be accounted for.

⁷ All these data were collected from the Roper Center data archives. Details about the sample sizes, question text, and other metadata are available in Appendix A.

Figure 1: Support for vote by mail expansion over time



First, overall public support for VBM has increased considerably over time. Whereas public support was consistently – and at times substantially -- below 50 percent between 1996 and 2018, every survey conducted during the pandemic shows overall public support well above 50 percent.

Second, partisan differences in the support for VBM have increased over time. Partisan differences are almost non-existent in surveys conducted prior to 2018, and only a small partisan gap was evident in 2018. In 2020, however, surveys regularly reveal a partisan gap of over 30 percentage points.

The aggregate patterns in Figure 1 are suggestive of the importance of partisan considerations, but limited in what they can reveal. It is impossible to discern, for example, the extent to which the increase in support for expanding VBM in 2020 is due to concerns with catching COVID-19, or the extent to which COVID-19 and partisan concerns vary over time by party. To disentangle the considerations that impact support for VBM requires individual level opinion data that also measures voters' fears about contracting COVID-19.

To identify the relative importance of partisan and COVID-19 considerations on support for expanding VBM over time we conduct two nationally-representative, cross-sectional surveys of registered voters to determine how concerns with catching COVID-19 impact support for VBM. Our first survey of 1,200 voters was conducted between April 8-11, 2020 by the survey research firm *Dynata* – formerly SSI. Voters were identified using the *Targetsmart* voter file and they were contacted via landlines, cell phones, and the web. Our second survey was conducted using the same size, sampling frame, and methodology between May 21-27, 2020.⁸

The timing of our surveys was fortuitous. Our initial survey was conducted immediately following the Wisconsin primaries – the period when discussions about expanding VBM to minimize COVID-19 exposure were widespread in the media because of lawsuits related to the counting of mail-in ballots in Wisconsin.⁹ The field period of our second survey overlapped with President Trump’s VBM “tweet-storm.” Presumably prompted by discussions related to VBM in the Wisconsin primaries, President Trump tweeted on April 8th that mail-in voting has a “tremendous potential for voter fraud” and “doesn’t work out well for Republicans.”¹⁰ During the field period of our two studies, President Trump tweeted about VBM once on May 1st, twice on May 8th, twice on May 20th, twice on May 21st, twice on May 24th, four times on May 26th, and three times on May 27th (Appendix I). Moreover, in April of 2020, House Democrats attempted to include a universal no-excuse absentee voting provision in a coronavirus relief bill (Montellero 2020) that was characterized by Republican House Minority Leader Kevin

⁸ A complete description of the sampling and weighting method for these surveys is available in Appendix B.

⁹ The lawsuits emerged after Wisconsin’s state Supreme Court blocked Governor Evers’ (D) attempt to delay the primary election and extend the deadline for mail-in ballots (Bradner, Sullivan, and de Vogue, 2020).

¹⁰ Donald Trump. April 8, 2020. *Twitter*. <https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1247861952736526336>. President Trump also tweeted about ballot harvesting on April 14th, but he connected it to the need for “VOTER ID. THE ONLY WAY TO GET AN HONEST COUNT!” (Donald Trump. April 8, 2020. *Twitter*. <https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1250067500190089217>).

McCarthy as a “distraction of continued attempts to force partisan objectives into our response [to the pandemic].”¹¹ Our second survey was collecting opinions about VBM at precisely the time when partisan considerations about expanding VBM were prevalent in the news.

To analyze public opinion towards election reforms, we asked respondents about their support or opposition to “proposals and reforms around voting and elections that have been offered to deal with the impacts of the coronavirus outbreak.” Respondents were asked specifically about whether they supported or opposed proposals to: “Expand access to vote-by-mail,” “Expand access to early voting,” “Increase the number of in-person polling places in order to minimize lines,” “Increase pre-paid postage for anyone who votes by mail,” and “Extend voter registration deadlines.”¹²

To provide an initial sense of public opinion on these issues, Table 1 reports the percentage of respondents answering either “strongly support” or “somewhat support” for each reform.

Table 1: Percentage who either “strongly support” or “somewhat support” reforms

	April 2020				May 2020			
	All	Dem	Rep	Ind ¹³	All	Dem	Rep	Ind
Extend voter registration deadlines	71	85	59	60	64	82	47	57
Increase the number of in-person polling places in order to minimize lines	80	85	79	64	78	81	78	67
Expand access to early voting	80	89	72	70	77	87	68	79

¹¹ Kevin McCarthy. April 1, 2020. *Twitter*. <https://twitter.com/GOPLeader/status/1245431874413105153>

¹²The order of these proposals on the survey were randomized. Respondents were first asked whether they support or oppose (order randomized) each reform. Then they were asked a follow-up question about whether they somewhat or strongly (order randomized) support/opposite the proposal.

¹³Independents here and throughout are “pure independents” – respondents who do not lean toward either party.

Expand access to vote-by-mail	73	90	58	63	65	85	44	63
Include pre-paid postage for anyone who votes by mail	74	86	64	67	70	86	53	63
N (weighted)	1200	562	472	139	1200	566	482	124

Many of the reforms we asked about receive bipartisan support in both early April and late May – e.g., more than 75 percent of Democrats and Republicans favored increasing the number of in-person polling places, and more than two-thirds supported expanding early voting. In terms of expanding VBM, however, public opinion shifted rather dramatically between our two surveys – overall support for expanding VBM dropped by 7 percentage points largely because of increased Republican opposition (Republican support decreased by 12 percentage points).

2. **Characterizing the Individual Level Support for VBM By Partisanship Over Time**

To decompose how support for expanding VBM varies by partisanship, concerns about catching COVID-19, and other differences such as whether a respondent lives in a VBM state we rely on a series of linear regressions.¹⁴ Regressions also allow us to estimate the conditional impact of these considerations on support for expanding VBM and how those effects vary in the six weeks between our two surveys. To provide a pre-pandemic baseline of the considerations that impact support for expanding VBM, we also analyze support for expanding VBM in the 2016 *Survey of the Performance of American Elections* using the same individual-level model.

To decompose support for expanding VBM we estimate a respondent’s support for expanding VBM as a function of: the vote-by-mail rules in the respondent’s state, an indicator for whether the respondent resides in a urban, suburban, or rural county, whether the respondent

¹⁴ Using a logit or probit provides substantively identically results, but we rely on a linear regression for expositional reasons.

voted in 2016 based on verified vote in the *Targetsmart* voter file, and self-reported measures of gender, race, age, education, and church attendance. To control for partisanship we include an indicator for self-identified Republicans (including leaners) and “pure” independents (self-identified Democrats (including leaners) are the omitted category). To control for the impact of COVID-19 concerns we include an indicator for whether a respondent replies that they are “Somewhat worried” or “Very worried” when asked: “How worried are you that you or someone in your family will contract the coronavirus?”¹⁵

Because we ask the same questions in our two national cross-sectional surveys, in addition to predicting support for expanding VBM using the 2016 SPAE data, we are also able to pool our surveys to estimate how the considerations impacting public opinion have changed during the pandemic. To do so we initially include an indicator for our May survey and interactions between the May indicator, partisan indicators, and the indicator for COVID-19 concerns. To ensure our results are robust, we also estimate the models separately by partisanship to allow every relationship to vary by party (Appendix E) and saturated models that allow interactions for party, COVID-19 concerns, and time (Appendix G).

Table 2 presents the results for the primary covariates of interest (Appendix C reports the full set of coefficient results).¹⁶ Specification (1) uses the 2016 SPAE data¹⁷; specifications (2) and (3) pool the April 2020 and May 2020 COVID surveys and allow the effect of partisanship and COVID concerns to vary over time.¹⁸ To highlight the importance of accounting for

¹⁵ The results are robust to using an indicator for “Very Worried”, creating and including indicators for every response category (except one), and relying on the 4-point linear response scale.

¹⁶ Appendix D reports the results of estimating specifications (2) and (3) separately for the April and May survey waves.

¹⁷ This survey used a slightly different question wording than the others: “Do you support or oppose any of the following proposals for new ways of voting or conducting elections? ... Run all elections by mail”.

¹⁸ Appendix E estimates the relationship separately for Democrats, Republicans, and Independents. As expected given the results of Table 2, the support of Democrats and pure Independents is stable over time and Republican support falls by about 12 points ($p < 0.001$).

COVID-19 concerns when interpreting the partisan difference in support for VBM evident in Figure 1 and Table 1, specification (2) ignores the impact of COVID-19 concerns and specification (3) accounts for the impact of changing COVID-19 concerns over time.

Table 2: Support for Expanding vote-by-mail

	Nov. '16 (1)	Pooled '20 (2)	Pooled '20 (3)
COVID Concern			0.10*** (0.03)
VBM state	0.20*** (0.01)	0.08** (0.03)	0.09** (0.03)
Excuse required state	-0.05*** (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)
Independent	-0.12*** (0.01)	-0.16*** (0.04)	-0.15*** (0.04)
Republican	-0.19*** (0.01)	-0.28*** (0.03)	-0.26*** (0.03)
May survey		-0.02 (0.02)	-0.13** (0.04)
Independent * May		-0.01 (0.06)	0.04 (0.06)
Republican * May		-0.10** (0.04)	-0.05 (0.04)
COVID Concern * May			0.13*** (0.04)
Constant	0.49*** (0.02)	0.91*** (0.04)	0.84*** (0.04)
Observations	9,476	2,142	2,142
R ²	0.09	0.18	0.22

Note: * p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001. Respondent survey weights are used. Appendix C reports full results.

Several insights emerge from the results reported in Table 2. First, all else equal, respondents living in states allowing for vote-by-mail (*VBM State*) were more supportive of expanding VBM expansion, and those living in states where VBM is highly restricted and an excuse is required to cast a ballot by mail (*Excused required state*) were more opposed. Together, these results suggest that voters' opinions are strongly influenced by the rules currently being used in their state –respondents appear to prefer the procedure being used by their state, on average, regardless of what that procedure is.

Second, consistent with the aggregate patterns noted in Figure 1, support for expanded vote by mail increases considerably between November 2016 and April 2020 regardless of

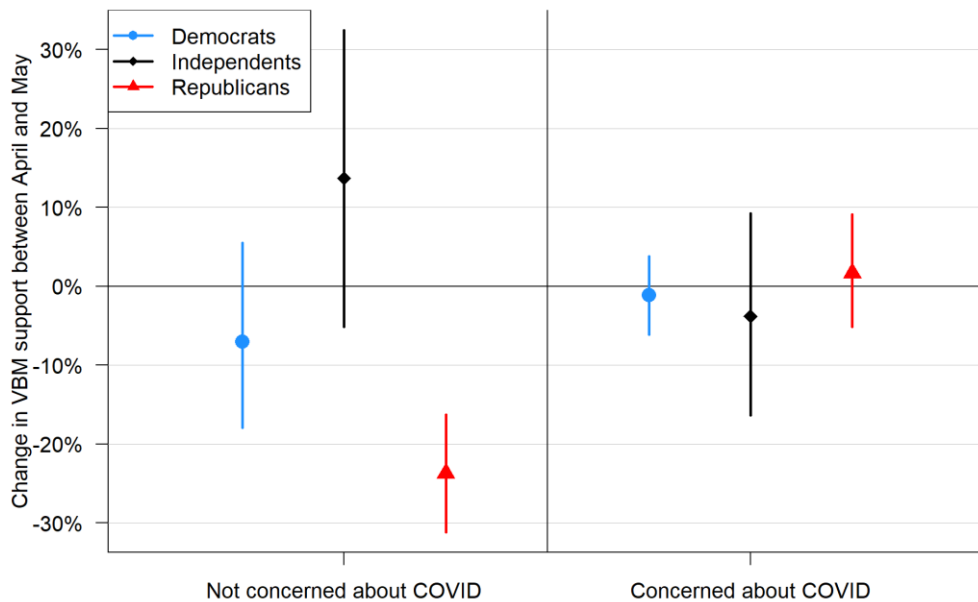
partisanship. In the 2016 data, an average of 49 percent of Democrats, 37 percent of Independents, and 30 percent of Republicans supported an expansion of voting by mail. Support increases to 91 percent, 75 percent, and 63 percent (respectively) in the April 2020 survey, and support remains similarly high in May 2020 – 89 percent, 74 percent, and 53 percent. The fact that support for VBM increases so much regardless of partisanship between 2016 and 2020 – nearly doubling in each of the party categories – is suggestive, but certainly not demonstrative of the pandemic’s impact. Unfortunately, without additional intermediate time-points, it is difficult to identify precisely how much of increased support in 2020 is due to the pandemic, but the fact that both Republicans and Democrats are more supportive despite increasing polarization on other issues suggests that the pandemic may have played an important role.

Specifications (2) and (3) quantify the extent to which Democrats and Republicans differ over time – and the extent to which those differences are due to COVID-19 concerns versus generic partisan differences that may be attributable to the increased partisan messaging that occurred on the issue between our April and May surveys. If COVID-19 concerns are ignored (Specification 2), not only are Republicans 28 percent less likely to support expanding VBM than Democrats in April (*Republican*), but their opposition appears to increase over time by another 10 percent in the six weeks between our two surveys (*Republican * May*). This 10 point growth in the gap over six weeks is more than half the size of the 19 point partisan gap in 2016 and it is roughly equal to the total growth in the gap between 2016 and April of 2020 – about 8 points. Pure independents are slightly less supportive than the baseline category of Democrats (*Independent*), but, unlike Republicans, their support for VBM is unchanged over time (*Independent * May*).

Comparing specifications (2) and (3) reveals how accounting for COVID-19 concerns affects our understanding of support for VBM in important ways. Specification (3) reveals the increasing importance of COVID-19 concerns for explaining support for expanding VBM over time. The relationship between COVID-19 concerns and support for VBM nearly doubles between April (*COVID Concern*) and May (*COVID Concern * May*). In April, respondents who were concerned with catching COVID-19 were 10 percentage points ($p < 0.001$) more likely to support VBM, but this effect increases by an additional 13 percentage points ($p < 0.001$) to over 23 percentage points in May 2020. In fact, the effect of COVID-19 concerns in May (+.23) is nearly the same magnitude as the difference between Democrats and Republicans (-.26). Republicans who are concerned with catching COVID-19 are as supportive of VBM as Democrats who are not.

To better understand how the partisan considerations are changing over time (and to ensure that our results persist when using a more saturated model) we estimate a fully interactive model that allows COVID-19 concerns to vary in importance between partisans over time. (Table 2 did not do so to highlight the relationship to 1996 opinions). Appendix G reports the full results, but Figure 2 plots the coefficients of substantive interest (and 95% confidence intervals) to show how partisanship and COVID-19 concerns interact over time to impact support for expanding VBM.

Figure 2: Changes in support for VBM over time



As Figure 2 makes immediately clear, the Republicans who were unconcerned with catching COVID-19 became increasingly opposed between April and May.¹⁹ In fact, among those concerned with catching COVID-19, there was no change in the support for VBM regardless of partisanship. Nor did the support of unconcerned Democrats and pure Independents change over time. Only among unconcerned Republicans did support for expanding VBM diminish-- they were 24 percentage points ($p < 0.001$) less supportive of VBM expansion in May than they were in April.

Given these results, there are two ways in Republican opposition to VBM has increased over time – presumably in response to the increased messaging by Republican elites. First, Republicans became less concerned with catching COVID-19 during the six weeks between our

¹⁹ The results in this figure come from a model which combines together the party and COVID concern variables into a six-category variable, and interacts that variable with the May indicator. The full results of this model are available in the appendix.

April and May surveys in general.²⁰ The percentage of Republicans who were concerned with catching COVID-19 fell from 60 percent in April to 46 percent in May.²¹ Insofar as Republican elites caused self-identified Republicans to become less concerned with COVID-19, their support for expanding VBM to help combat the spread of COVID-19 fell as a consequence. In contrast, there was only a slight decline in concern among Democrats (86 percent concerned in April to 82 percent concerned in May), and pure Independents (74 percent concerned to 59 percent concerned).

A second way in which Republican opposition increased occurred through the increased opposition to VBM among Republicans who are unconcerned with catching COVID-19. This is the only statistically distinguishable change in support for expanding VBM over time in Figure 2—again suggesting that the increased partisan messaging by President Trump and others succeeded in increasing Republican opposition among unconcerned Republicans (in addition to also perhaps decreasing Republicans’ concern with COVID-19).

Despite the drop-off in Republican support in May 2020 because of diminished concerns with catching COVID-19 and the increased opposition to expanding VBM among those unconcerned with catching COVID-19 we identify, it is important to note that a majority of respondents (51%) support VBM. Even among Republicans, 44 percent of Republicans support VBM (partially because of their fear of catching COVID-19). The level of support for VBM we

²⁰ See, for example: Adam Gabbatt. “Faced with an appalling US coronavirus death toll, the right denies the figures.” May 15, 2020. *The Guardian*. <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/may/15/coronavirus-death-toll-right-denies-figures>. And: Vincent T. Davis. “Bexar County GOP chair denounces coronavirus as hoax by Democratic Party.” May 23, 2020. *San Antonio Express-News*. <https://www.expressnews.com/news/local/article/Bexar-County-GOP-chair-denounces-coronavirus-as-15291431.php>

²¹ As the results of predicting COVID-19 concerns in Appendix F make clear, when we control for additional demographics in a regression, we find that this decrease-over-time for Independents and Republicans is significantly different from zero ($p < 0.05$), and there is no significant change among Democrats.

observe in May 2020 is far greater than the support for VBM in 2016 when only 30 percent of Democrats and Independents and 16 percent of Republicans supported VBM.

3. Impact on Other Electoral Reforms?

The effects we detect for VBM are interesting and important, but they raise questions as to whether other proposed election reforms were similarly impacted. Insofar as support for the other reforms were due to concerns with catching COVID-19 then it seems likely that the pattern of support for other electoral reforms would vary similarly to the patterns we identify for expanding VBM. If, however, support for the other reforms are unrelated to the current pandemic then opinions should not vary by COVID concerns.

To examine the contours of public opinion on electoral reforms we estimate the correlates of respondents' support for: "expand access to early voting," "include pre-paid postage for anyone who votes by mail," "increase the number of in-person polling places in order to minimize lines," and "extend voter registration deadlines." For the sake of comparison, Table 3 reports the results using the same specifications used by specifications (2) and (3) in Table 2.

Table 3: Support for other election reforms

	Expand early		Free postage		Add polling places		Extend registration	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
COVID Concern		0.06*		0.07*		0.03		0.05
		(0.03)		(0.03)		(0.03)		(0.03)
Independent	-0.09*	-0.08*	-0.10*	-0.09*	-0.14***	-0.13***	-0.17***	-0.17***
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)
Republican	-0.15***	-0.13***	-0.19***	-0.17***	-0.06*	-0.05	-0.24***	-0.23***
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)
May survey	-0.01	-0.05	0.02	-0.03	-0.03	-0.02	-0.03	-0.08
	(0.02)	(0.04)	(0.02)	(0.04)	(0.02)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)
Independent * May	0.05	0.07	-0.07	-0.04	0.12*	0.12*	-0.000	0.02
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)

Republican * May	-0.03 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.10** (0.04)	-0.07 (0.04)	0.06* (0.03)	0.06 (0.03)	-0.07 (0.04)	-0.05 (0.04)
COVID Concern * May		0.05 (0.04)		0.06 (0.04)		-0.01 (0.04)		0.06 (0.04)
Constant	0.86*** (0.04)	0.81*** (0.04)	0.92*** (0.04)	0.87*** (0.05)	0.80*** (0.04)	0.77*** (0.04)	0.93*** (0.04)	0.89*** (0.05)
Observations	2,153	2,153	2,139	2,139	2,121	2,121	2,122	2,122
R ²	0.06	0.08	0.13	0.14	0.02	0.02	0.13	0.14

Note: * p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001
Additional controls included (see Appendix H for full results)

Table 3 presents the results to reveal several conclusions worth noting. First, there is strong bipartisan support for all four election reforms. In both April and May, every policy we consider has the support of at least three-quarters of Democrats, two-third of Independents, and half of Republicans.

Second, in contrast to support for expanding VBM, respondents' support for these reforms is not highly impacted by COVID-19 concerns. In fact, concern for COVID-19 was significantly related to support for just two of the four reforms – expanding early voting and allowing for pre-paid postage of mail ballots – and the magnitude of these effects were just 6 and 7 points respectively (compared to a magnitude of 10 points for VBM).

Finally, unlike what was observed when predicting support for VBM, changing COVID-19 concerns did not produce significant shifts in attitudes toward these policy proposals – none of the coefficients for the interaction COVID concern and May were significantly discernable from a null effect. This is a dramatic difference from VBM expansion, where those concerned about COVID become 13 percentage points more supportive between April and May.

Together, these results suggest that support for these reforms are not conditioned by COVID-19 concerns. As a result, public support for expanding early voting, increasing the number of polling stations, and paying for the postage of absentee and mail ballots (presumably

referring to existing VBM) are qualitatively differently than public opinions regarding VBM. The fact that support does not depend on COVID-19 concerns suggests – but certainly does not prove – that these are reforms that voters think should occur regardless of the pandemic. That is, voters would like more early voting, more polling places, and free postage if they are able to vote by mail.²²

4. Conclusion

Public opinion polls have revealed a large – and increasing partisan gap in whether VBM should be expanded in response to the COVID-19 pandemic. These shifts have occurred during the same time period that elite messaging about VBM have become amplified. This leads to the question of what might be responsible for the increasing gap – are opinions changing because partisans are following the cues their partisan leaders are providing on VBM, or are the differences because of changes in how concerned partisans are with catching COVID-19 (perhaps because of partisan cues)?

By conducting two new nationally representative surveys of known registered voters we are able to better identify the relationship between partisanship and concern with catching COVID-19 on support for expanding VBM over time. By controlling for both partisan and COVID-19 concerns over time, we are able to disentangle the reasons for why support for VBM changes over time and how those reasons vary.

We show that the increasing partisan gap in support for VBM between April and May 2020 is driven by Republicans becoming less supportive of expanding VBM through two pathways. Although Republicans who are concerned with catching COVID-19 are as supportive of VBM in May as they were in April, Republicans are less concerned with catching COVID-19

²² While interesting, it is unfortunately beyond our ability to discern why respondents use different considerations when evaluating VBM relative to these other proposed reforms.

over time. Perhaps due to partisan cues about the nature of the pandemic, insofar as the expansion of VBM is seen as a remedy for voting during a pandemic, the fact that Republicans are increasingly unconcerned with COVID-19 has dampened their support for VBM.

A second way in which Republican opposition has increased is through the increased opposition of unconcerned Republicans. Whereas the support for expanding VBM is largely stable among Democrats and pure Independents, Republican support has fallen by more than 20 points during the six-week period between our surveys among those who are unconcerned with catching COVID-19. It seems likely that the increasing opposition among this group is likely due to increased elite messaging, but it is impossible for us to prove the causal connection with the available data.

Our results show that non-partisan considerations matter for public support of expanding VBM – concern with catching COVID-19 increases support for expanding VBM even among Republicans, but partisan considerations have an increasingly important impact on support for VBM. Public opinion on VBM became more partisan over time not only because concern with catching COVID-19 became more partisan, but opposition to expanding VBM among Republicans unconcerned with catching COVID-19 also increased in response to partisan messaging by President Trump and other Republican leaders.

Even so, it is important to underscore the overall popularity of VBM. According to our late May survey results, a majority of nearly every demographic group – women, men, black, Hispanic, white, under 30, over 65 – supports expanding VBM (and support exceeds 80 percent in many cases). The largest group opposed to expanding VBM are Republicans who are unconcerned with COVID-19, but even 44 percent of this group supports VBM at the end of May despite the active partisan messaging around VBM that has occurred. Insofar as public

support is essential for encouraging electoral reforms, concerns with catching COVID-19 has moved public opinion to support VBM as a method of conducting elections. Partisan differences in opinion have steadily increased, but even among Republicans there is significant support for VBM – support that was previously nearly non-existent.

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Appendix A

Summary of surveys used in Figure 1. The 1996 Pew and the April 2020 AP polls randomized the question stem. The numbers in Figure 1 treats these as the same question. Separating them out has no significant impact on the graph.

Source	Sample size	Dates	Question text
Pew Research Center for the People & the Press	1500	Feb. 22-25, 1996	Currently most states do not allow voting by mail except for absentees. Overall, do you favor or oppose changing the election laws to allow everyone to vote by mail?
Pew Research Center for the People & the Press	1500	Feb. 22-25, 1996	All things considered, do you favor or oppose changing the election laws to allow everyone to vote by mail?
NBC News, Wall Street Journal	2107	Dec. 7-10, 2000	I'm going to read you a list of possible measures that could be taken to improve the way Americans vote. For each one, please tell me whether you favor or oppose this measure.... More voting by mail
Pew Research Center for the People & the Press, Associated Press	1804	Sep. 21-Oct 4, 2006	Some states are using an election system in which residents are allowed to cast their vote through the mail in the weeks leading up to the election if they want to. Do you strongly favor, favor, oppose or strongly oppose allowing people to vote by mail before election day instead of in a voting booth on election day?
Pew Research Center for the People & the Press	2449	Sep. 24-Oct 7, 2018	(Please indicate whether you would favor or oppose the following ideas about election policy.)...Conduct all elections by mail
Pew Research Center for the People & the Press	4917	Apr. 7-12, 2020	(Please indicate whether you would favor or oppose the following ideas about election policy.)...Allowing any voter to vote by mail if they want to
Associated Press	1057	Apr. 16-20, 2020	Do/Would you favor, oppose, or neither favor nor oppose your state doing each of the following?...Allowing people to vote by mail-in ballot instead of in-person without requiring them to give a reason
Associated Press	1057	Apr. 16-20, 2020	If the country is facing a coronavirus outbreak in November (2020), would you favor, oppose, or neither favor nor oppose your state doing each of the following for

			the 2020 presidential election?...Allowing people to vote by mail-in ballot instead of in-person without requiring them to give a reason
Gallup	1016	Apr 14-28, 2020	Would you favor or oppose your state allowing all voters to vote by mail or absentee ballot in this year's (2020) presidential election?
Fox News	1207	May 15-20, 2020	In response to the coronavirus pandemic, do you favor or oppose allowing all United States citizens to vote by mail in the upcoming (2020) presidential election?
ABC News/Washington Post	1001	May 25-28, 2020	Do you support or oppose states making it easier for people to cast an absentee ballot or vote by mail instead of going to a polling place to vote?

Appendix B

Telephone interviews were drawn from a random sample of registered voters across the United States, sampled from the TargetSmart voter file. Online interviews from the Dynata online panel were also all matched back to the TargetSmart voter file. In total, both surveys reached 1,200 respondents who indicated they are registered to vote. A breakdown of the sample size by mode for each survey is in the table below. The first survey was conducted from April 8 – 11, 2020 and the second survey from May 21 – 27, 2020. Quotas were designed to reflect the demographic and geographic distribution of registered voters in the United States. The data were weighted by gender, age, modeled race, modeled partisanship, modeled education, modeled vote propensity, population density (at the census bloc level), and geography (at the state level) to ensure an accurate reflection of the population. The overall credibility interval for both surveys is $\pm 2.8\%$.

Mode	April 8 – 11	May 21 – 27
Cell phone	372	474
Landline	228	126
Online	600	600

Appendix C

Full version of Table 2, including all control covariates. None of these additional controls have significant results that have consistent effects.

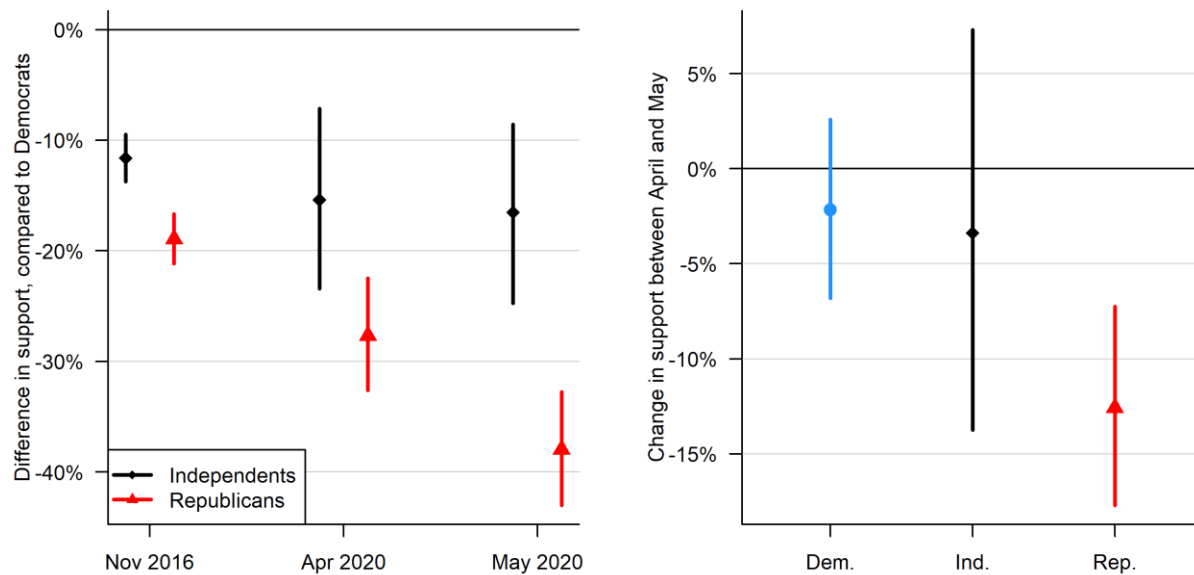
Support for expanded vote-by-mail			
	Nov. '16 (1)	Pooled '20 (2)	Pooled '20 (3)
COVID Concern			0.10*** (0.03)
VBM state	0.20*** (0.01)	0.08** (0.03)	0.09** (0.03)
Excuse required state	-0.05*** (0.01)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)
Independent	-0.12*** (0.01)	-0.16*** (0.04)	-0.15*** (0.04)
Republican	-0.19*** (0.01)	-0.28*** (0.03)	-0.26*** (0.03)
Suburban	0.01 (0.01)	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)
Urban	0.05*** (0.01)	0.06* (0.02)	0.05* (0.02)
Voted 2016	-0.14*** (0.02)	-0.07*** (0.02)	-0.08*** (0.02)
Female	-0.02** (0.01)	0.05** (0.02)	0.04* (0.02)
Black	0.01 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)
Hispanic	0.004 (0.02)	0.02 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)
Other race	0.03 (0.02)	0.001 (0.04)	-0.005 (0.04)
Age: 30-64	-0.02 (0.01)	-0.003 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)
Age: 65+	-0.04** (0.01)	-0.03 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)
Some college	-0.04*** (0.01)	0.01 (0.03)	0.01 (0.02)
College grad	0.01 (0.01)	0.04 (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)
Post-grad	0.03* (0.02)	0.04 (0.03)	0.03 (0.03)
Church weekly	-0.03** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.07)	-0.04 (0.07)
May survey		-0.02 (0.02)	-0.13** (0.04)
Independent * May		-0.01 (0.06)	0.04 (0.06)
Republican * May		-0.10** (0.04)	-0.05 (0.04)
COVID Concern * May			0.13*** (0.04)
Constant	0.49*** (0.02)	0.91*** (0.04)	0.84*** (0.04)
Observations	9,476	2,142	2,142
R ²	0.09	0.18	0.22

Note: * p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001

To more easily characterize these results, Figure 2 plots the regression coefficients (and 95% confidence intervals) for the party indicators measuring the difference in support relative to

Democrats (the baseline category). The left-hand plot reports the partisan gaps from Model (2) over time, and the right-hand plot graphs the effects over time by partisanship.

Figure 2: Party Gap in Support for VBM Expansion



As the left-hand plot in Figure 2 makes clear, Republicans were 19 percentage points ($p < 0.001$) less supportive of expanding VBM than Democrats in November 2016 and independents were 12 points less supportive ($p < 0.001$). By early April 2020, the partisan gap between Democrats and Republicans had grown by 9 points to 28 percentage points and the gap grew by 10 additional points in May 2020. The question is whether that partisan gap is driven by movement by both Democrats and Republicans, or whether it was mostly one-sided.

We can answer this question by considering the interaction coefficients from Model (2). The right side of Figure 2 shows the differences in opinion for each party between April and May, taking into account the interaction and lower-order coefficients. As the graph shows, there was no significant change in the level of Democratic support for VBM expansion in the six weeks between the April and May surveys (-0.02 ; $p > 0.05$). Nor was there a change in support

among Independents (-0.03; $p>0.05$). We did see, however, a dramatic change in the attitudes of Republicans whose support for VBM expansion diminished by 12 points ($p<.001$) between April and May. This resulted in the gap between Democrats and Republicans in VBM support growing significantly ($p<0.01$) from 28 percentage points in April to 38 percent points in May.

Appendix D

Estimating the relationship for each survey wave separately produces results that are consistent with those reported in Table 2. Independents did not have a significant change in attitudes between April and May (relative to Democrats). Prior to controlling for COVID concern, Republicans had a double-digit drop in support for expanded VBM. After including that control, this change became indistinguishable from a null effect. The marginal effect of the COVID Concern variable is positive in both months, and its magnitude grew significantly between April and May.

Support for expanded vote-by-mail, by month

	Apr. '20 (1)	May '20 (2)	Apr. '20 (3)	May '20 (4)
COVID Concern			0.09*** (0.03)	0.24*** (0.03)
VBM state	0.07 (0.04)	0.10* (0.04)	0.07 (0.04)	0.12** (0.04)
Excuse required state	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.05 (0.03)	-0.10*** (0.02)	-0.05* (0.03)
Independent	-0.16*** (0.04)	-0.16*** (0.04)	-0.15*** (0.04)	-0.11* (0.04)
Republican	-0.28*** (0.03)	-0.38*** (0.03)	-0.26*** (0.03)	-0.30*** (0.03)
Suburban	0.01 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.01 (0.03)
Urban	0.04 (0.03)	0.08* (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	0.06 (0.03)
Voted 2016	-0.04 (0.03)	-0.10*** (0.03)	-0.04 (0.03)	-0.12*** (0.03)
Female	0.04 (0.02)	0.05 (0.03)	0.04 (0.02)	0.05 (0.02)
Black	-0.01 (0.04)	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.001 (0.04)	-0.06 (0.04)
Hispanic	-0.07 (0.04)	0.09* (0.04)	-0.06 (0.04)	0.09* (0.04)
Other race	-0.02 (0.05)	0.03 (0.07)	-0.02 (0.05)	0.01 (0.07)
Age: 30-64	0.02 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.04)	0.01 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.03)
Age: 65+	-0.07 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	-0.08 (0.04)	0.02 (0.04)
Some college	0.04 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.04)	0.04 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.04)
College grad	0.03 (0.03)	0.04 (0.04)	0.03 (0.03)	0.04 (0.04)
Post-grad	0.05 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	0.05 (0.04)	-0.01 (0.04)
Church weekly	0.04 (0.10)	-0.10 (0.09)	0.03 (0.10)	-0.09 (0.09)
Constant	0.90*** (0.05)	0.90*** (0.06)	0.83*** (0.05)	0.74*** (0.06)
Observations	1,088	1,054	1,088	1,054
R ²	0.16	0.22	0.17	0.27

Note: * p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001

Appendix E

These results support our conclusions from Table 2. Republicans were the only group for whom there was a significant difference in support between April and May (based on Model 3). Also, Republicans who were not concerned about COVID in the May study were 23 points ($p < 0.001$) less supportive of VBM expansion than they were in April. Republicans who were concerned about COVID were 2 points (not significant) more supportive of VBM expansion in May than April. Neither Democrats nor Independents had similar over-time changes, conditional on COVID concern. These findings are substantively the same as those presented in Table 2.

Support for expanded vote-by-mail, by party						
	Dem	Ind	Rep	Dem	Ind	Rep
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
COVID Concern				0.07	0.34***	0.06
				(0.04)	(0.10)	(0.05)
VBM state	0.03	-0.06	0.16**	0.03	-0.02	0.19***
	(0.03)	(0.11)	(0.06)	(0.03)	(0.11)	(0.06)
Excuse required state	-0.03	-0.16*	-0.11**	-0.03	-0.15*	-0.10**
	(0.02)	(0.07)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.07)	(0.03)
Suburban	0.04	0.07	-0.02	0.04	0.09	-0.03
	(0.02)	(0.08)	(0.04)	(0.02)	(0.08)	(0.04)
Urban	0.05	0.11	0.09*	0.05	0.13	0.05
	(0.02)	(0.08)	(0.05)	(0.02)	(0.08)	(0.05)
Voted 2016	-0.01	-0.07	-0.14***	-0.02	-0.09	-0.14***
	(0.02)	(0.06)	(0.04)	(0.02)	(0.06)	(0.03)
Female	-0.002	0.19**	0.06	-0.000	0.17**	0.05
	(0.02)	(0.06)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.06)	(0.03)
Black	-0.06*	-0.003	0.19	-0.06*	-0.06	0.14
	(0.02)	(0.10)	(0.14)	(0.02)	(0.10)	(0.13)
Hispanic	-0.02	0.11	0.04	-0.02	0.08	0.06
	(0.03)	(0.11)	(0.07)	(0.03)	(0.11)	(0.07)
Other race	-0.05	0.01	0.07	-0.05	-0.05	0.06
	(0.04)	(0.11)	(0.09)	(0.04)	(0.11)	(0.09)
Age: 30-64	0.01	-0.000	-0.03	0.01	-0.03	-0.04
	(0.02)	(0.09)	(0.06)	(0.02)	(0.08)	(0.05)

Age: 65+	0.02	0.10	-0.11	0.03	0.06	-0.12*
	(0.03)	(0.12)	(0.06)	(0.03)	(0.11)	(0.06)
Some college	0.001	-0.005	0.02	0.000	-0.02	0.02
	(0.03)	(0.09)	(0.05)	(0.03)	(0.09)	(0.05)
College grad	0.04	-0.04	0.06	0.04	-0.04	0.06
	(0.03)	(0.09)	(0.05)	(0.03)	(0.09)	(0.05)
Post-grad	0.03	-0.04	0.04	0.02	-0.06	0.04
	(0.03)	(0.10)	(0.05)	(0.03)	(0.09)	(0.05)
Church weekly	-0.13	-0.01	0.09	-0.14	-0.04	0.11
	(0.08)	(0.18)	(0.14)	(0.08)	(0.18)	(0.14)
May survey	-0.02	-0.03	-0.12***	-0.06	0.12	-0.23***
	(0.02)	(0.06)	(0.03)	(0.05)	(0.11)	(0.05)
COVID Concern * May				0.05	-0.15	0.25***
				(0.05)	(0.13)	(0.06)
Constant	0.89***	0.70***	0.71***	0.84***	0.49***	0.69***
	(0.04)	(0.13)	(0.07)	(0.05)	(0.14)	(0.08)
Observations	1,074	205	863	1,074	205	863
R ²	0.03	0.11	0.09	0.04	0.18	0.14

Note: * p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001

Appendix F

Independents and Republicans were significantly less concerned about their own personal health than Democrats in April. By May, Democrats' level of concern had not changed, while Republicans and Independents had significant drops in their level of concern.

Concern for personal or family's health due to COVID

DV: Concerned/not concerned about health	
Independent	-0.09* (0.04)
Republican	-0.24*** (0.03)
Suburban	0.02 (0.02)
Urban	0.05* (0.02)
Voted 2016	0.01 (0.02)
Female	0.03 (0.02)
Black	0.003 (0.03)
Hispanic	-0.02 (0.03)
Other race	0.02 (0.04)
Age: 30-64	0.05 (0.03)
Age: 65+	0.05 (0.03)
Some college	-0.003 (0.03)
College grad	-0.004 (0.03)
Post-grad	0.03 (0.03)
Church weekly	0.01 (0.07)
May survey	-0.04 (0.03)
Independent * May	-0.14* (0.06)
Republican * May	-0.10* (0.04)
Constant	0.76*** (0.04)
Observations	2,279
R ²	0.12

Note: * p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001

Appendix G: Saturated Model for Supporting VBM Over Time

This is the model used to construct Figure 2.

Support for expanded vote-by-mail, saturated by party and COVID concern

VBM state	0.10** (0.03)
Excuse required state	-0.07*** (0.02)
Concerned Dem	0.08 (0.05)
Unconcerned Ind	-0.37*** (0.09)
Concerned Ind	-0.01 (0.06)
Unconcerned Rep	-0.25*** (0.05)
Concerned Rep	-0.19*** (0.05)
Suburban	0.01 (0.02)
Urban	0.05* (0.02)
Voted 2016	-0.07*** (0.02)
Female	0.04* (0.02)
Black	-0.03 (0.03)
Hispanic	0.02 (0.03)
Other race	-0.01 (0.04)
Age: 30-64	-0.01 (0.02)
Age: 65+	-0.03 (0.03)
Some college	0.01 (0.02)
College grad	0.04 (0.03)
Post-grad	0.03 (0.03)
Church weekly	-0.04 (0.07)
May survey	-0.07 (0.06)
May * Concerned Dem	0.06 (0.07)
May * Unconcerned Ind	0.21 (0.11)
May * Concerned Ind	0.03 (0.09)
May * Unconcerned Rep	-0.17* (0.07)
May * Concerned Rep	0.08 (0.07)
Constant	0.86*** (0.05)
Observations	2,142
R ²	0.22

Note: * p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001

Appendix H: Full Results for Other Election Reform Specifications

Table 3 in the text reports substantively interesting covariates from this table.

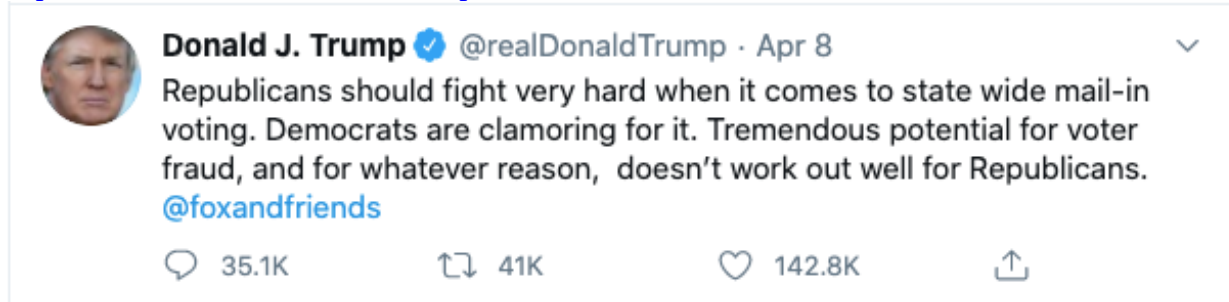
Support for other election reforms

	Expand early		Free postage		Add polling places		Extend registration	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
COVID Concern		0.06*		0.07*		0.03		0.05
		(0.03)		(0.03)		(0.03)		(0.03)
VBM state	0.06*	0.06*	0.06*	0.07*	0.005	0.01	0.04	0.04
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Excuse required state	-0.02	-0.02	-0.08***	-0.07***	-0.02	-0.02	0.01	0.01
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
Independent	-0.09*	-0.08*	-0.10*	-0.09*	-0.14***	-0.13***	-0.17***	-0.17***
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)
Republican	-0.15***	-0.13***	-0.19***	-0.17***	-0.06*	-0.05	-0.24***	-0.23***
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Suburban	0.01	0.01	-0.01	-0.01	0.02	0.02	0.03	0.03
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
Urban	0.03	0.03	0.02	0.01	0.04	0.04	0.05*	0.05*
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
Voted 2016	0.002	0.000	-0.05**	-0.05**	0.03	0.03	-0.05**	-0.05**
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
Female	0.05***	0.05**	0.07***	0.07***	0.04*	0.04*	0.03	0.03
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)
Black	-0.05*	-0.05*	0.01	0.01	-0.04	-0.04	-0.03	-0.03
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Hispanic	-0.01	-0.01	0.03	0.04	0.04	0.04	-0.04	-0.04
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Other race	-0.08*	-0.08*	0.003	-0.000	-0.005	-0.005	-0.06	-0.06
	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)
Age: 30-64	0.03	0.02	-0.07**	-0.08**	0.03	0.03	-0.05*	-0.05*
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Age: 65+	-0.02	-0.02	-0.10***	-0.10***	0.05*	0.05*	-0.16***	-0.16***
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Some college	0.02	0.02	0.03	0.03	0.01	0.01	0.02	0.02
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)
College grad	0.03	0.03	0.05*	0.05*	0.003	0.002	0.001	0.001
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Post-grad	0.04	0.04	0.04	0.04	0.01	0.004	0.04	0.04
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.03)	(0.03)
Church weekly	-0.05	-0.05	0.003	0.004	0.03	0.03	0.15*	0.15*
	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.07)	(0.07)
May survey	-0.01	-0.05	0.02	-0.03	-0.03	-0.02	-0.03	-0.08

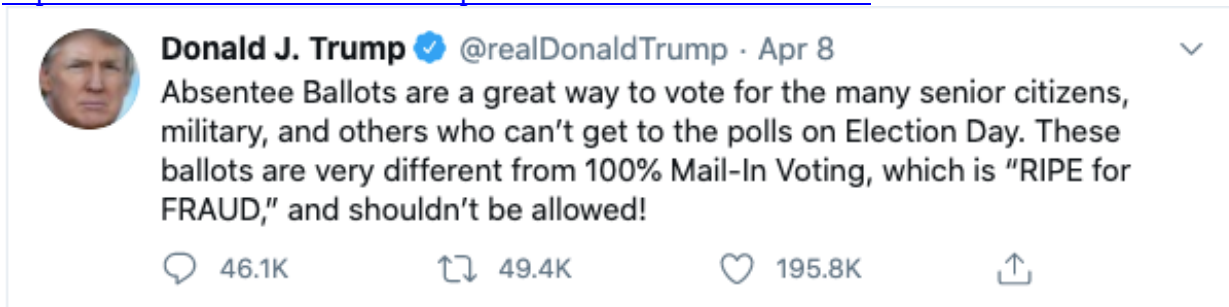
	(0.02)	(0.04)	(0.02)	(0.04)	(0.02)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.04)
Independent * May	0.05	0.07	-0.07	-0.04	0.12*	0.12*	-0.000	0.02
	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)	(0.05)	(0.05)	(0.06)	(0.06)
Republican * May	-0.03	-0.01	-0.10**	-0.07	0.06*	0.06	-0.07	-0.05
	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.03)	(0.03)	(0.04)	(0.04)
COVID Concern * May		0.05		0.06		-0.01		0.06
		(0.04)		(0.04)		(0.04)		(0.04)
Constant	0.86***	0.81***	0.92***	0.87***	0.80***	0.77***	0.93***	0.89***
	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.04)	(0.05)
Observations	2,153	2,153	2,139	2,139	2,121	2,121	2,122	2,122
R ²	0.06	0.08	0.13	0.14	0.02	0.02	0.13	0.14
Note:	* p<0.05; ** p<0.01; *** p<0.001							

Appendix I: President Trump's VBM Tweets for the Time Period of our Surveys

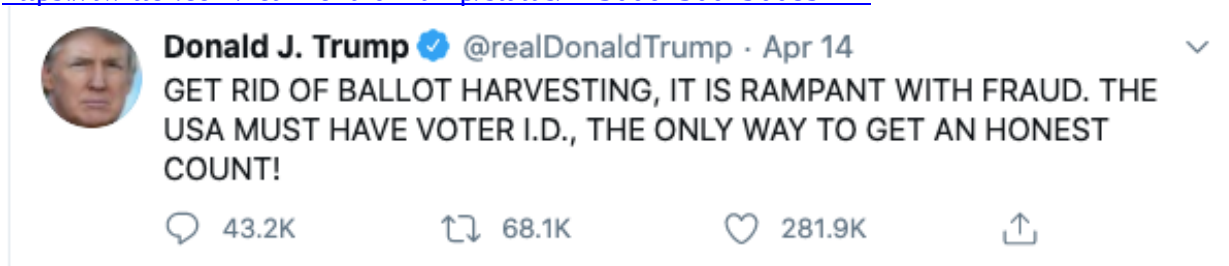
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<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1250067500190089217>



<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1256366878873792512>



Donald J. Trump ✓ @realDonaldTrump · May 1

Don't allow RIGGED ELECTIONS!



Mollie ✓ @MZHemingway · Apr 30

Nearly one in five of all absentee and mail-in-ballots between 2012 and 2018 remain unaccounted for, according to data from the federal Election Assistance Commission. [realclearpolitics.com/articles/2020/...](https://www.realclearpolitics.com/articles/2020/...)



25.4K



38K



120.8K



<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1263170880298942464>



Donald J. Trump ✓ @realDonaldTrump · May 20

Michigan sends absentee ballot applications to 7.7 million people ahead of Primaries and the General Election. This was done illegally and without authorization by a rogue Secretary of State. I will ask to hold up funding to Michigan if they want to go down this Voter Fraud path!



36.3K



36.7K



128.6K



<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1263094958417985538>



Donald J. Trump ✓ @realDonaldTrump · May 20

State of Nevada "thinks" that they can send out illegal vote by mail ballots, creating a great Voter Fraud scenario for the State and the U.S. They can't! If they do, "I think" I can hold up funds to the State. Sorry, but you must not cheat in elections. @RussVought45 @USTreasury



36.1K



30K



103.1K



Donald J. Trump Retweeted



Kambree ✓ @KamVTV · May 21

Well I'll be...

South Carolina election ballots found in Maryland this week.



South Carolina election ballots reportedly found in Maryland this week
South Carolina election ballots reportedly ended up in Maryland this week, after mail-in voting for the state's June 9 primary has already ...
[foxnews.com](https://www.foxnews.com)

1.9K

13.7K

27.4K



Donald J. Trump Retweeted



CatchTheHook @NavyFlyBoyUSA · May 21

Is anyone buying that DimLib's massive Vote-by-Mail plan is secure? I can confirm that voter rolls are 33% full of moved people/dead people. They will be sending 12 ballots to a home that has been sold 4 times. Old names are active. We can't accept this fraud. #maga #tcot #kag



Geller Report @PamelaGeller · May 21

South Carolina Absentee Ballots Found in Maryland as Democrats Push for Vote-by-Mail Increases dlvr.it/RX6r9B



2K

10K

22.3K



<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1264717545787006976>



Donald J. Trump @realDonaldTrump · May 24

The Democrats are trying to Rig the 2020 Election, plain and simple!



Donald J. Trump @realDonaldTrump · May 24

The United States cannot have all Mail In Ballots. It will be the greatest Rigged Election in history. People grab them from mailboxes, print thousands of forgeries and "force" people to sign. Also, forge names. Some absentee OK, when necessary. Trying to use Covid for this Scam!

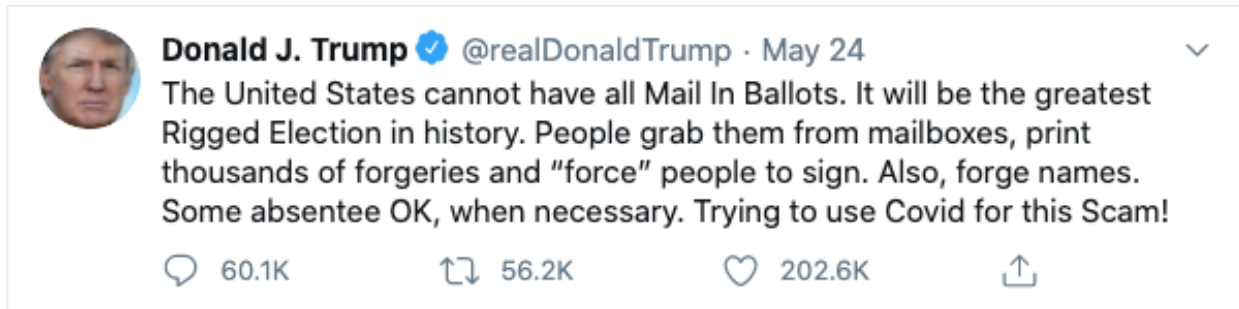
23.1K

27.5K

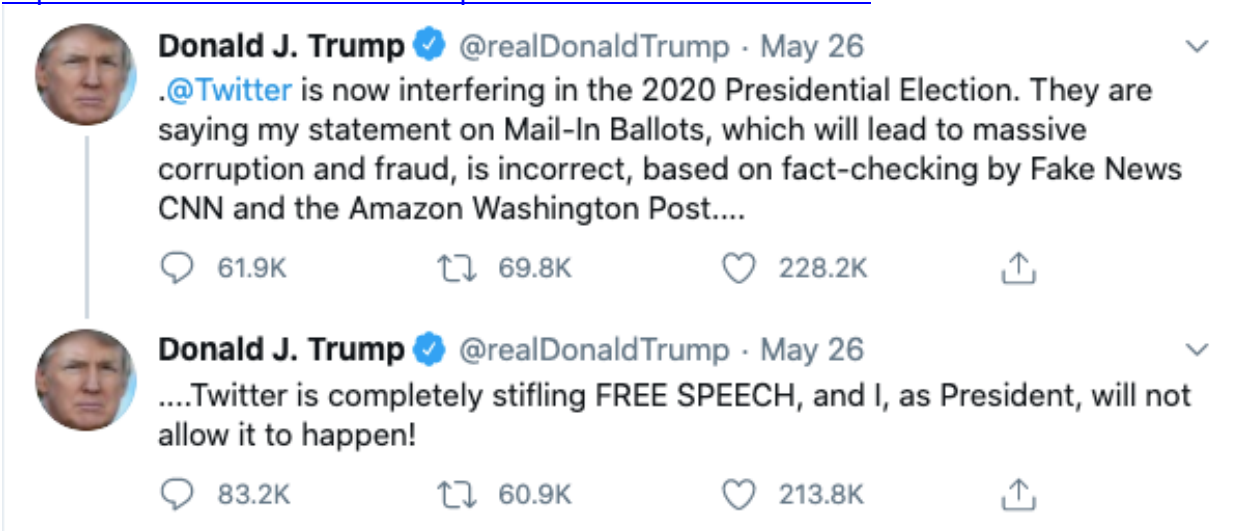
87K



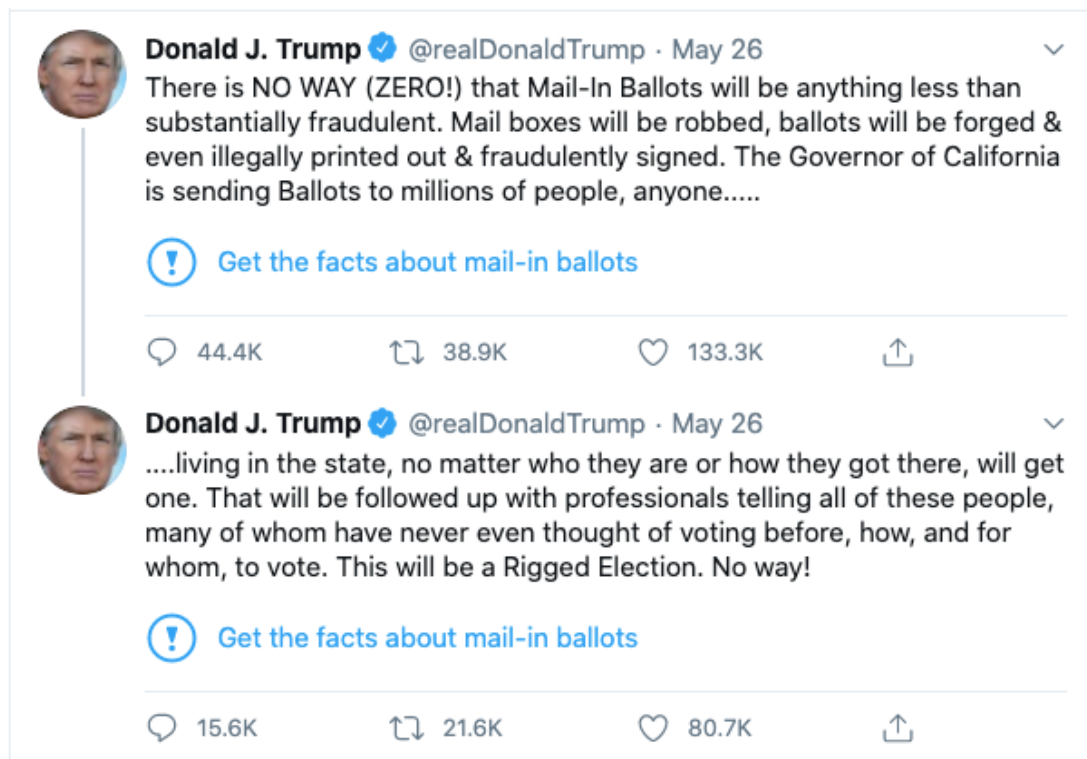
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<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1265427539008380928>



<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1265255845358645254>



<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/126582703270702000>



<https://twitter.com/realDonaldTrump/status/1265601615261827072>



Donald J. Trump ✓ @realDonaldTrump · May 27

Republicans feel that Social Media Platforms totally silence conservatives voices. We will strongly regulate, or close them down, before we can ever allow this to happen. We saw what they attempted to do, and failed, in 2016. We can't let a more sophisticated version of that....

32.2K

36.8K

133.2K



Donald J. Trump ✓ @realDonaldTrump · May 27

....happen again. Just like we can't let large scale Mail-In Ballots take root in our Country. It would be a free for all on cheating, forgery and the theft of Ballots. Whoever cheated the most would win. Likewise, Social Media. Clean up your act, NOW!!!!

16.7K

23.6K

87.5K

